

Message in a Bottle

Scene Director's Handbook

24 scenes · step-by-step GM procedures · full spoilers · unplaytested fan edition



Campaign by Austen Tucker-Crowder. Requires the separately available Savage Worlds Adventure Edition core rules. Not official Pinnacle material.

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A practical, scene-by-scene running guide for *Message in a Bottle*

GM eyes only. Every page contains spoilers. This is a companion to the full adventure, not a replacement for the scene statistics, maps, core SWADE rules, or player handouts. The PDF release appends this handbook to the original illustrated GM book. The standalone handbook is useful as a separate screen or printout.

Edition: Free Fan Edition 0.1, expanded GM guidance; written and mechanically checked, **not playtested**.

Guidance below explains how to run the established 24 scenes without dictating player choices. If a suggested example conflicts with a player's established action, keep their action and use the scene's essential clue and outcome to improvise forward.

The five-minute GM briefing

- **Prep for a gathering:** Read its three scenes, essential clues, and outcome states in the main book. Put the next player handout face down. Jot the names and current attitude of Mark, Pip, Inez, Calder, and any living allies who matter. Prepare SWADE Action Cards, Bennies, three blank clock tracks, and the stat blocks indicated by that gathering.
- **Open:** Read the gathering's boxed introduction in the main book, or paraphrase it. Ask *one* concrete question about what the heroes are doing right now. Don't narrate their feelings or put decisions in their mouths.
- **Run each scene:** (1) Name the visible problem. (2) Give two obvious approaches and allow a third. (3) State the stake and the consequence *before* asking for a roll. (4) Resolve with the main book's listed Trait check, Quick Encounter, Dramatic Task, or Social Conflict. (5) Deliver the essential clue even when the roll fails. (6) End with a decision that points to the next scene.
- **Use SWADE normally:** The ordinary Trait target is 4 unless the core rules or the encounter specify otherwise. Raises matter; failure creates a cost, new pressure, or an opponent's move. Bennies, Support, Tests, Action Cards, Wounds, and Incapacitation work as in the core book. These notes are not replacement rules.
- **Protect agency:** The clues are guaranteed; the advantages aren't. Never require success on Research to learn a fact essential to the only way forward. Don't decide Calder escapes, that the party fires, or that the final bargain is rejected. The final scene responds to choices.
- **Use safety tools:** Before play, ask privately about boundaries around abduction, confinement, memory changes, displacement, civic disaster, and physical danger. Agree on a pause/rewind method. Don't demand a public explanation for a boundary. Check in when the city is shaken or citizens are described as property.
- **Pace:** Treat the times below as flexible targets for a 3–4-hour gathering. A scene can be shortened to its clue and one consequential choice if the table is running late. Never turn a 20-minute action into a one-hour search for a mandatory clue.

Session 0: Bring Mark Back

Before play: Decide with the table whether Mark is a player-controlled hero or the listed support NPC. Put an empty three-box Portal Instability clock and an eight-token/three-round Dramatic Task tracker where everyone can see them. Have two rift leech profiles ready. **Suggested pacing:** reunion and plan 25–40 minutes; portal task 50–70; aftermath and bonds 25–40; character setup takes the remaining time. **Do not reveal** the auction, Calder, or the Keeper yet.

0A. Agree the return (0-plan)

Set the table: A garage-sized frame stands between exposed cables. Mark knocks from the other side. The crew can study power, alignment, and bracing without a roll. **Say:** "You have a return signal, a frame, and maybe three pulses before the window shifts. What does each of you take charge of?"

1. Ask each player to name a job, a piece of familiar equipment, or someone they brought to help. Write the choices down; they become useful props later.
2. Describe the scorched tape in plain view: *Keep an anchor at both ends. Do not wait for the third pulse.* Offer Notice, Electronics, or Repair if someone wants to learn *why* it burned. On a success, let them choose which feed will be safer when the next complication hits. On failure, they still read the warning.
3. Ask what they want Mark to find waiting at home. Keep the answer for the Chicago scenes.

If they hesitate: Point at the three leads: power, alignment, bracing. **If they skip planning:** Move directly to the first task round; a rushed feed becomes the first complication. **End when:** Everybody has a job and a personal reason to bring Mark home.

0B. Build the portal (0-build)

Set the table: Draw three feeds and put the 8-token/3-round goal beside them. **Say:** "The return window opens. You can get Mark through, but something will have to hold the frame together."

1. Start the SWADE Dramatic Task and deal Action Cards according to the core rules. Let players describe a specific contribution before choosing Electronics, Repair, Athletics, or another justified Trait. Support and nontechnical solutions are welcome.
2. After every incomplete round, fill one Portal Instability box. In round two, put **two rift leeches** on exposed cables. Explain visibly that attached leeches stop that feed contributing. A hero may lure a leech with a battery without a roll, remove it with Athletics/Repair, or fight it using the appendix stat block.
3. Count tokens openly. Introduce task complications only when their card/rule calls for them. Announce the result after round three; do not secretly add a fourth round to force success.

On a miss: The task changes the damage and loss, not whether Mark returns. **If someone ignores the feed:** A leech steals power until dealt with; any other feed remains usable. **End when:** The window surges and Mark appears.

0C. Let the first mistake matter (0-return)

Set the table: The frame buckles; Mark has one foot in Chicago. **Say:** "You can save the machine, keep the creatures contained, or protect everyone nearby. Which matters most?"

1. Apply task success or failure from 0B. On success, the frame survives. Otherwise let the group choose or see one cost: broken frame, escaped leech, or a localized wrong-weather patch.
2. Offer one brief remaining-leech fight *only if* the crew wants it. Keep danger recoverable and allow surrender, containment, or retreat.
3. Let Mark speak as a frightened friend, not a plot encyclopedia. He remembers timed crossings and a label suggesting inhabited worlds were in a collection, but cannot name the collector or explain Calder.

If Mark is a PC: Ask that player what they remember; offer only the established route facts. **If everyone is injured:** Treat injuries under SWADE; let an ally help with shelter and recovery rather than cancel the campaign. **End when:** Someone welcomes Mark home; ask where the group will meet again.

Session 1: Chicago Is Safe

Before play: Revisit the places named in Session 0 and the chosen portal cost. Prepare a contractor seal, one ordinary local witness, Pip, and a small map of a public transit location. **Pacing:** homecoming 35–50; reality errors and rescue 45–60; Pip 30–45; conversation and Advance afterward. Deliver the first Advance at the end.

1A. Visit something worth saving (1-home)

Set the table: Return to a restaurant, stoop, arcade, train stop, or other place a player invented. **Say:** "Everything is almost exactly as you left it. Who recognizes you here?"

1. Go around the table once: ask each player for a local person, sensory detail, and the smallest thing that's changed in ten years.
2. Make friendly NPC conversation free. Call for Persuasion, Common Knowledge, or Research only if a hero seeks privileged information or risks offense. Mark can contribute one incomplete travel memory, never the whole mystery.
3. Show the same restoration contractor seal on two separate repaired surfaces. Let the players photograph or copy it without rolling.

If they leave quickly: Bring the second seal into the street ahead of them. **If they chase the company immediately:** Give them a public address, not the whole conspiracy. **End when:** The table names at least one piece of Chicago worth saving and notices an odd repetition.

1B. One harmless error, then one costly error (1-error)

Set the table: A transit announcement contradicts a street sign, then an impossible doorway reveals a stranded rider. **Say:** "The platform is just a few steps away, except the steps lead somewhere they didn't a moment ago."

1. Describe the contradiction clearly; do not ask for Notice to see it. The witness also remembers the old sign, though records don't.
2. Present a rescue choice: cross, direct the rider to the service exit, or coordinate transit staff. Use one suitable Trait check per risky approach or a short core Quick Encounter.
3. Before each roll name the cost: lost equipment, security attention, or delay. On a failed roll keep the rider reachable through the ordinary exit.

If the group argues the geometry: Agree one consistent passage rule for this scene and let them test it. **If they refuse the rescue:** The rider gets out with transit workers and tells them about the panel crew. **End when:** The witness or evidence points to weatherization panels.

1C. The first undeniable cartoon (1-cartoon)

Set the table: Pip, a living toon-bodied resident, enters carrying a painted umbrella; their shadow arrives late. **Say:** "I'm not supposed to be on this side. Please don't send me back until I know it's safe."

1. Ask whether the heroes shelter, escort, question, or contain Pip. Make Pip an informed person with preferences, never a punchline.
2. Let patient conversation establish that Pip's neighborhood is real and had different physics before the shaking. If trust is strained, Persuasion can help. Failed Persuasion makes Pip cautious, not silent forever.
3. Give the crew a practical next step: identify who installed the panels before the incursion. Record whether Pip is an ally, a wary witness, or has fled.

If Pip flees: Leave the painted umbrella, route mark, and a civilian who saw the departure. **If heroes threaten Pip:** Show the consequences to trust, while preserving the route clue. **End when:** The crew agrees what it will do about the next overlap.

Session 2: Ink and Paint

Before play: Draw three hazards: bus, exit corridor, shifting boundary. Prepare an 8-token/4-round rescue task, a six-box Public Danger clock, and one contractor Extra per hero. Stage Handout 2 face down. **Pacing:** physics 30; rescue 60–90; evidence and fallout 35–50.

2A. Establish the local physics (2-rules)

Set the table: A painted crosswalk peels off the road, separating two terrified groups. **Say:** "The door is painted on. It still opens. A falling sign stops in midair for a heartbeat before dropping."

1. Establish three repeatable local rules: elastic ladder, painted door connecting opposite sides of one wall, delayed falling objects. Demonstrate each harmlessly.
2. Invite one safe experiment. No roll for learning the rule. A risky crossing uses Athletics, a justified technical Trait, or another concrete approach.
3. State a modest failed-crossing cost before the roll. Pip, if present, explains that these laws belong to a real neighborhood.

If players exploit the painted door: Reward that creativity; don't change the rule to block them. **If Pip is absent:** A displaced resident provides the same truth. **End when:** The group understands the physics well enough to plan a rescue.

2B. Save the people on both sides (2-rescue)

Set the table: Show bus, escape route, boundary; mark 8 Task Tokens in 4 rounds and the six-box danger clock. **Say:** "You can stabilize this, but nobody can cover all three jobs alone."

1. Let each hero pick anchoring, evacuation, boundary work, or Support. Use Athletics, Repair, Electronics, or Persuasion when the narrated action fits. Deal task Action Cards and count tokens openly.
2. In round two, point to the falling sign *before* resolving damage. Moving people out of its zone prevents harm; otherwise Agility avoids 2d6 damage on failure.
3. Contractors arrive, **one per hero**, aiming to restrain Pip. Offer command-level negotiation, a distraction, or combat. A cooperative contractor can prioritize evacuation.
4. At the end of any round when **no one** addressed civilians, fill a danger box. At six boxes another group is stranded, still rescuable.

If the task fails: Civilians require a second response and property may be damaged, but the story continues. **If heroes attack contractors:** Use Extra profiles; survivors may surrender and still carry the records. **End when:** Rescue stabilizes or shifts to follow-up, and a contractor's premature knowledge is apparent.

2C. Follow the cleanup (2-paper)

Set the table: A discarded dispatch sheet has a Thompson routing mark and a timestamp before the emergency. **Say:** "The supplies arrived before anyone reported the damage."

1. Hand over **Handout 2** automatically from a worker, kit, or notice. Don't lock it behind a victory or roll.
2. Research verifies the timing; a raise reveals an additional matching contract. Failure means surveillance or bureaucratic trouble, not loss of the sheet.
3. Ask what the team does with helpful or hostile contractors. Record an ally or an opponent for Session 3.

If the party burns the document: A photo or public work order preserves the essential facts. **If they go straight to Thompson:** Let them learn its department name but keep the maze confrontation for when they have leverage. **End when:** The team knows that prediction, profit, and Thompson are connected.

Session 3: Shake the Snow Globe

Before play: Put three investigation options on one index card: records, depot, witness. Prepare Inez and Calder, plus the crew's contractor relationship. **Pacing:** investigation 45–60; outside shake 30–45; Calder 45–60. Award the second milestone Advance afterward.

3A. Offer three ways into the pattern (3-routes)

Set the table: Three leads are simultaneously available. **Say:** "You can follow the money, the equipment, or the people who were there. Where do you start?"

1. At records, Inez shares public invoices; Research adds a shell account. At the depot, workers show schedules; Stealth or Persuasion yields private manifest details. At a witness site, someone saw pulsing equipment; Electronics identifies the Thompson control destination.
2. Give the core pattern without a check at every route: repeated equipment serials and advance preparation. Checks win extra certainty, privacy, and leverage.
3. A failure costs time, discretion, or cooperation. Have the group choose whether to pursue a second lead or confront Calder.

If they split up: Cut between two brief scenes; don't punish the split with missing clues. **If they already distrust Inez:** Public records provide the same essential proof. **End when:** The common serial and Thompson destination are established.

3B. Show the hand outside (3-shake)

Set the table: A curved reflection catches the skyline as the whole city tilts. **Say:** "The horizon moves independently of the buildings. For a moment you can see a wall curving around all of Chicago."

1. Warn of a short shake; offer saving a stranger or preserving footage/equipment as visible priorities.

2. Use a normal appropriate Trait roll for a risky intervention. Success changes who is saved or what evidence is kept, not whether players recognize deliberate shaking.
3. If they miss the shot, a witness has a recording. If they don't intervene, make the civilian consequences concrete and recoverable.

If someone tries contacting the outside hand: Offer a distorted signal or pause in the motion, not a premature audience with the Keeper. **End when:** Everybody understands this is privilege exercised intentionally, not a routine malfunction.

3C. Confront the beneficiary (3-calder)

Set the table: Calder offers the heroes contracts and influence before reaching for an alarm. **Say:** "You're clearly capable. I could use people who solve problems rather than make speeches about them."

1. Ask whether they negotiate, expose, arrest, stalk, or attack. Roleplay his aim: preserve control over repair revenue and reach Thompson if cornered.
2. If a contested negotiation matters, use core Social Conflict. If he runs, use a short Chase. If captured or defeated, the key and documents still identify Thompson. Do **not** declare an automatic escape.
3. On any outcome, reveal that Calder was the human beneficiary, not the qualified external bidder. His phrase for the arrangement is "enrichment."

If Calder cooperates: Let him trade the route and one favor for protection. **If Calder dies:** A deputy's order preserves the destination. **End when:** Players choose how to enter Thompson, with Calder's fate recorded.

Session 4: The Thompson Center Maze

Before play: Place the five-node fictional map (A ticket hall; B departures; C records; D controls; E seam) beside you. Have Handout 3 ready, a four-box Maze Shift clock, and custodians at half the party count rounded up. **Pacing:** navigation 40–50; ledger 40–50; controls 45–60.

4A. Choose a route through jurisdiction (4-ticket)

Set the table: All three offices insist another office has jurisdiction. **Say:** "The ticket has been printed three different ways. Every counter says you are at the wrong counter."

1. Show A connecting visibly to B and C. Calder's key opens one node for free. At B, helping stranded travelers earns a transit badge and path to D. At C, a clerk offers an estate ledger.
2. Let a roll save time, prevent suspicion, or win a shortcut. Never roll for finding the other route. Mark one shift box for repeated unchanged tactics or an accepted delay.
3. At four boxes send custodians, one per two heroes rounded up; they warn, can negotiate, and can retreat.

If they bypass offices: Reward an imaginative route into D or C while still delivering the ledger. **If they get lost:** An embarrassed clerk points them to C. **End when:** They can distinguish buyer and beneficiary.

4B. Make the deal legible (4-ledger)

Set the table: The public ledger names Up's estate, the Keeper's bid, and Calder's benefit. **Say:** "Chicago appears under estate inventory. There is no line for the consent of its residents."

1. Give **Handout 3** without a roll. Answer plainly: Up died in an accident, the estate sold the inhabited holding, and the Keeper acquired shaking rights.
2. Invite questions and ethical reactions. Research or Persuasion can find a severance record or a procedural weakness, but not a hidden murder plot.
3. If the team tries legal remedies, let them suspend one shake or free a custodian. Complete severance still needs the physical seam or an equally substantial table-developed alternative.

If they try to sue the estate: Make the hearing a chance to earn an injunction or access, not an endless dead end. **If they reject legal procedure:** The seam diagram is still obtainable. **End when:** The group decides whether to disable the shake system or race straight to the seam.

4C. Choose what to disable (4-seam)

Set the table: At D sits a shake switch; at E is a diagram of the ownership seam and a route to fictional Loop Resonance Works. **Say:** "Turning off the tremors buys people time. Breaking the seam would end the claim itself."

1. Offer two active problems: disabling the local shake feed (Electronics, Repair, or plausible physical action) and securing the seam diagram. The diagram is visible even on failed rolls.
2. On success, record *first accelerator hazard prevented*. On failure, cost a tool or introduce a custodian; do not erase the diagram.
3. Give Calder any ending the players earned: captured, bargaining, surrendered, or gone. Clarify the beam cracks ownership without transporting Chicago.

If players propose demolition: Let them understand who is at risk, and offer targeted feed isolation as an option. **If they depart at once:** They still know where to go. **End when:** Each hero names one thing or person they intend to protect during the firing.

Session 5: Crack the Bottle

Before play: Draw fictional Loop Resonance Works with three feeds and two exits. Prepare a 12-token/4-round task, six-box Earthquake clock, two rift leeches, and contractors equal to half the crew rounded up. The machine is imaginary: no real accelerator engineering needed. **Pacing:** arrival 30–40; activation 60–90; earthquake and separation 35–50.

5A. Reach the fictional test hall (5-arrive)

Set the table: Dr. Vale shows power, calibration, containment, and a crowded evacuation corridor. **Say:** "You have one shot at the seam, but not everyone here knows what's about to happen."

1. Ask each hero to choose a concrete role: power, calibration, containment, evacuation, or defense. Dr. Vale answers questions but does not operate the mission for them.
2. Apply the Thompson switch choice. If disabled, the first hazard is a warning. Otherwise announce a falling panel at a service exit; Athletics or Repair can protect that route.
3. Establish visibly that the beam targets a supernatural ownership seam, not real infrastructure or citizens.

If the team refuses to fire: Let them plan evacuation or seek alternatives; don't trigger the task until they commit. **If Mark is absent:** Other power sources and technical choices remain viable. **End when:** The team has assigned roles and states its firing conditions.

5B. Activate under pressure (5-fire)

Set the table: Start 12 Task Tokens over 4 rounds; put the earthquake track next to it. **Say:** "Four cycles to align the seam. Every cycle makes the floor less trustworthy."

1. Resolve a SWADE Dramatic Task with Action Cards. Electronics runs power/calibration, Repair contains, Athletics braces, Persuasion coordinates civilians. Support applies normally and earns no independent tokens.
2. Add two leeches in round two; narrate the visibly blocked feed. In round three contractors equal to half the heroes rounded up arrive unless an ally kept them away.
3. Add one earthquake box every activation round. Before a risky containment action warn that a Critical Failure adds an extra box, then use core task consequences as well.
4. Track participation, task progress, and exposed civilians openly. Do not make Dr. Vale solve an unattended role.

If combat runs long: Keep initiative for threats but preserve the four task rounds as announced. **If the crew is underpowered:** Offer civilians and allies as Support, never free victory tokens. **End when:** The firing attempt resolves.

5C. Choose a cost and let the world open (5-break)

Set the table: The seam strains while the ground cracks. **Say:** "The city can stay here. The boundary may not survive. What do you save first?"

1. If the task succeeded, sever the seam. If it failed, offer an emergency firing that works but damages the hall and fills the earthquake track; **do not force acceptance**. Refusers can retreat, repair a portable feed, and retry later.
2. At six earthquake boxes, warn exposed heroes about debris and give Agility to reach cover; failure deals 2d6 damage. A prepared evacuation saves civilians automatically.
3. When the boundary breaks, describe Chicago remaining in Chicago while the heroes are ejected to a service platform outside. Show the platform's auction plate as potential vessel material.

If someone sacrifices equipment or leverage: Make it matter in Session 6. **If they seek to stay in Chicago:** Give them a concrete choice and consequence before departure; don't seize their characters by fiat. **End when:** The surviving travelers see the primordial sea and decide how to travel.

Session 6: Adrift in the Universe

Before play: Show three possible stops (stranded train, elven departures, auction dock) and a six-box Slide Departure clock. Ready **Handout 4**. Two stops make a satisfying gathering, but allow a different itinerary.

Pacing: vessel 45; two stops 65–85; timed crossing 35–50.

6A. Build a way to travel (6-vessel)

Set the table: The auction platform floats above a strange foggy sea. **Say:** "You have material for a boat, a route instrument, and an astonishing amount of nowhere. What kind of vessel can this crew build?"

1. Have players name its shape; then ask how it gets power, steers, and reads a route. Each part needs a suitable successful Trait roll; Support is welcome.
2. A missed roll creates a repair beat or a limitation (slow speed, noisy drive, fragile hull). Never destroy the vessel outright before travel starts.
3. Give **Handout 4** and connect its signal to a Chicago location the group previously named. Mark may power a part but cannot make all the choices.

If they want to walk or fly: Use the same three functional needs for their proposed travel method. **If no materials remain:** The platform itself has detachable plates, cable, and bolts. **End when:** The crew names its vessel and chooses the first stop.

6B. Choose two stops, not a tour checklist (6-islands)

Set the table: Show three destinations on separate index cards: train, departures, dock. **Say:** "Each harbor offers a route home, but none of them will hold still forever."

1. At the **train**, rescuing passengers costs two travel beats and wins a signal lamp; leaving costs one beat and leaves someone in need. At **departures**, two custodians demand a badge; negotiate, use the ledger, evade, or fight for a route stamp. At the **dock**, search one beat for spare anchors and refuse or negotiate a repossession shortcut that would renew a claim.
2. Run each stop with one or two justified Trait rolls or a Quick Encounter. Show consequences first. Reset the six-box slide clock when arriving at a new stop.
3. Any **one** lamp, stamp, or anchor identifies the home route; **two** grant +1 on the finale's first calibration. Don't require visiting every island.

If they invent another port: Reskin a listed opportunity and cost without erasing the essential direction. **If they accept the repossession's offer:** Record the promised ownership claim explicitly. **End when:** A plausible signal home is in hand and the next opening is visible.

6C. Leave before the slide closes (6-cross)

Set the table: Display six departure boxes and describe an opening visible across the sea. **Say:** "You have a short window. The vessel needs someone to steer and someone to hold the anchor."

1. Require one navigation and one anchoring check using sensible Traits. Other heroes can Support, guard, or deal with a visible obstacle.
2. Fill the clock after meaningful travel beats, including extra repairs and rescues. At six, the current slide closes; the crew can wait with one new cost or take another offered route.
3. If both anchors are lost, show a catchable cable or an allied tow immediately. This is a perilous detour, not campaign-ending limbo.

If the group tries the wrong opening: Describe the landmark discrepancy before locking the decision; let them back out at a price. **If they choose to wait:** Provide a tangible repair, rescue, or resource challenge. **End when:** Everyone knows the home signal and can see the final approach.

Session 7: Message in a Bottle

Before play: Prepare 8 Task Tokens over 3 rounds, a four-box Final Tether clock, the reposessor's Wild Card stat block, and the Chicago place chosen for the signal. Recall whether the team gained two travel preparations.

Pacing: message 35–45; confrontation 60–90; epilogues 35–50. The ending should belong to the table, not a preset cutscene.

7A. Make home recognize them (7-message)

Set the table: Chicago is too far away to see; a familiar place offers a route signature. **Say:** "Someone on the other side can help, but they need to know where to look. What do you tell home?"

1. Ask every hero for one line of the message, and one meaningful job sending or stabilizing it.
2. Establish the named Chicago location and a signal of **three long flashes and one short**. Electronics, Repair, Persuasion, or justified methods send it. If the crew earned two travel preparations, the first calibration attempt gets +1.
3. Mark, if an NPC, supplies current while the heroes choose the destination. If the lamp is missing, use visible cable and a repair beat.

If someone has a better encoding idea: Accept it if it identifies the same chosen place. **If they distrust help at home:** Ask what person or memory the signal should reach; don't require named NPC survival. **End when:** Home answers and the reposessor reveals its claim.

7B. Resist the last claim (7-claim)

Set the table: An unmistakable tether attaches to the vessel. The reposessor politely offers safe passage in exchange for restoring the ownership boundary. **Say:** "I can guarantee your return. The terms are exceptionally reasonable, provided the city remains secured."

1. Put the tether's terminal visibly within reach. Announce choices: bargain, fight, delay, cut, or break the terminal. Electronics or Repair disables it at -2; the exposed terminal has Toughness 6. Defeating the reposessor is not required.
2. Start the 8-token/3-round Dramatic Task for alignment and crossing. Each hero chooses between contributing, Support, and addressing the tether. Use Action Cards and SWADE task rules.
3. Fill one Final Tether box after each finale round while the attachment remains. At four boxes the agent boards, but the terminal remains removable and the exit possible.

If players take the bargain: State the cost in plain language and record acceptance; do not present it as freedom. **If they defeat the agent early:** Keep the tether as a technical objective until severed. **End when:** The task and tether states are both known.

7C. Resolve the crossing, then listen (7-home)

Set the table: Resolve two independent facts: did the party align home, and is the Keeper's tether disabled?

Say: "You can see home. What did your choices cost, and who is waiting?"

1. **Task succeeds, tether disabled:** Free return. **Task succeeds, tether active:** The bow reaches Chicago but the vessel stays held; residents help while the crew gets a final opportunity to sever the terminal or force release.
2. **Task fails:** The window closes onto an anchored island. Offer a visible repair and next-cycle retry, with a damaged vessel or delayed homecoming as the cost. **Bargain accepted:** Return with ownership compromised, naming that problem openly rather than declaring victory.
3. Invite each player to narrate one changed relationship, one place visited first, and one promise for the future. Give the final line to a person or place the heroes saved.

If they refuse an ending you anticipated: Ask what concrete step they take next, use the established mechanics, and let their chosen outcome stand. **End when:** Players, not the GM, have described what freedom and homecoming mean for their characters.

One-page handoff between scenes

At the end of every scene, jot: **who is safe, what changed, what clue is now known, what cost was paid, who is now an ally or adversary, and which two next actions are visible.** If a clue is unclear, restate it in the fiction before the next roll. A failed roll changes leverage or pressure, not access to the only path forward. Between gatherings, update the heroes' chosen Chicago anchor, Calder's fate, Pip's trust, the status of workers and custodians, the portal frame, any repaired vessel, and whether the final tether/bargain remains outstanding.

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